

What gets in the way of reading and writing?

Eight underlying skills that can create barriers to literacy for dyslexic and neurodivergent learners, and what each one can affect.



MEMORY AND PROCESSING

Working and short-term memory

Holding information in mind while you work with it.

CAN AFFECT

- Spelling
- Decoding
- Building sentences
- Comprehension
- Using several sources
- Drafting and editing

Processing speed

How quickly information is taken in, understood and acted on.

CAN AFFECT

- Work rate
- Reading fluency
- Writing fluency
- Comprehension
- Using several sources
- Drafting and editing

WORD-LEVEL PROCESSING

Phonological awareness

Hearing, telling apart and working with the sounds in spoken words.

CAN AFFECT

- Decoding
- Spelling
- Word reading
- Reading fluency
- Learning new vocabulary

Visual processing

Seeing, remembering and telling apart letters and other visual symbols.

CAN AFFECT

- Word recognition
- Spelling
- Reading fluency
- Letter confusion (b/d, p/q)
- Automaticity
- Keeping your place in text

SELF-MANAGEMENT

Executive function

Planning, organising, staying focused, self-regulating and adapting.

CAN AFFECT

- Planning and structuring
- Drafting
- Editing and proofreading
- Checking for meaning
- Comprehension
- Time and attention

Motor skills and sensory processing

Planning and coordinating movement, and responding to sensory information.

CAN AFFECT

- Handwriting
- Posture
- Writing fluency
- Writing stamina
- Using writing tools
- Attention
- Self-regulation

LANGUAGE

Vocabulary, grammar and sentence structure

Knowing and using words, grammar and sentence patterns.

CAN AFFECT

- Understanding
- Word choice
- Sentence structure
- Punctuation
- Tense and grammar

Language comprehension and expression

Understanding and using language in everyday, functional ways.

CAN AFFECT

- Comprehension
- Understanding text types
- Expressing ideas
- The writer's voice

Every learner's profile is different. Most people have a mix of strengths and difficulties across these areas, and a difficulty in one can make others harder. A Learning Needs Assessment builds a clear picture of the individual, so support can target what matters most.

Yorkshire Wolds Dyslexia Service

Learning Needs Assessments · 1:1 literacy intervention
Pocklington, and within about 20 miles

Adapted from an original resource by Louise Selby, Dyslexia Specialist (louiseselbydyslexia.com).

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